

Bernard Letters 124-127

Epistolae de schismate Petri Leonis, 124–127 (*Letters on the Schism of Anacletus II, 124–127*)

by St. Bernard of Clairvaux (1090–1153), written c. 1131–1132

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- *Latin text: Patrologia Latina 182, coll. 268–282, after the electronic transcription of the Binetti edition hosted by Documenta Catholica Omnia; obvious transcription slips corrected, and the principal passages verified against the PL scan.*
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Note on this selection: these letters belong to Bernard’s campaign for Innocent II during the schism of 1130–1138, when rival conclaves elected Innocent II and Anacletus II (Pietro Pierleoni, “Petrus Leonis”). They are the repository’s earliest witness after Auxilius to the principle that the Church’s reception settles a contested claim to the papacy. Bernard’s situation is the mirror-image of the later formulated doctrine: the election was divided, so he argues toward universal acceptance rather than from it — but the criteria he deploys and the finality he assigns to the achieved consensus are the doctrine’s raw materials. Ep. 124 gives the compact triple criterion: “the election by the better men, the approval of the more, and — what is more effective than these — the testimony of his character commend Innocent to all and confirm him supreme pontiff.” Ep. 125 adds the celebrated formula: “Deservedly does the Church receive him, whose reputation is the brighter and whose election the sounder, prevailing both in the number and in the merit of the electors.” Ep. 126 — the whole letter, translated here in full — is his systematic case to the bishops of Aquitaine against Gerard of Angoulême, Anacletus’s legate: it argues that the second election was canonically null from the start (§8: “after a first election there is no second”); that God has already judged the cause “by the evidence of the deed, not by the sentence of a decree” (§9), listing the adhering archbishops, bishops, monastic orders (§10), and kings and peoples (§11); and that the remnant’s demand to re-judge the confirmation is absurd — “they summon the world to court, and with their handful demand that the universality be judged... It is the business

of the universal Church, not the cause of a single person” (§11). Ep. 127, written in the name of Duke Hugh of Burgundy to William of Aquitaine, draws the practical maxim later theology would formalize: “It is safer for you, in the reception of the universal pope, not to depart from the consensus and counsel of the universality: him whom all the religious orders, whom the universality of kings have received, it is for you also honorable and salutary to receive.” Note that Bernard nowhere reduces the case to acceptance alone — he argues persons, election, and priority (Ep. 126 §13: “the worthier elect, the sounder election, the more orderly proceeding”) — but the function he gives to the universal adhesion, as God’s own judgment rendering the cause irreversible and resistance schismatic, is precisely what the seventeenth-century doctrine would articulate. Compare the 1517 Cajetan entry (the Church’s adoration of Nicholas V against the surviving antipope Felix as “notorious testimony”) and the 1563 Cano entry (the Church holding Eugene IV for true pope); and contrast the 1534 Castro entry, where the same divided-obedience scenario grounds the opposite lesson about the theological note.

Letter 124 — To Hildebert, Archbishop of Tours, who had not yet received the lord Pope Innocent (PL 182, coll. 268–269)

He urges him to acknowledge Innocent, exiled in France on account of the schism of Petrus Leonis, as legitimate pontiff.

To the great priest, HILDEBERT, exalted in the word of glory, by the grace of God archbishop of Tours: BERNARD, called abbot of Clairvaux — that he may walk in the Spirit, and examine all things spiritually.

1. To address you in the words of the prophet: Comfort is hidden from my eyes, because death divides between brothers (Osee 13:14). For certain men, as Isaiah says, seem to have struck a covenant with death and made a pact with hell (Isai. 28:15). For behold, this anointed of the Lord, Innocent, is set for the ruin and for the resurrection of many. For those who are of God are gladly joined to him; but he who stands against him is either of Antichrist, or is Antichrist. The abomination is seen standing in the holy place; and to gain that place, fire has burned the sanctuary of God. He persecutes Innocent, and with him all innocence. Innocent flees, indeed, from the face of the Lion — as the prophet says: The lion shall roar, who shall not fear? (Amos 3:8) — he flees according to the precept of the Lord, who says: If they persecute you in one city, flee to another (Matth. 10:23). He flees; and in this he proves himself truly an apostolic man, that he bears the apostolic stamp. For Paul did not blush to be let down through the wall in a basket, and so to escape the hands of those who sought his life (Act. 9:25). He fled, not to spare his own life, but giving place to wrath; not to evade death, but to gain life. Deservedly does the Church yield to Innocent the office of him in whose very footsteps she sees him walking.
2. Nor indeed is Innocent’s flight without fruit. He labors, it is true; but he is honored in his labors. Driven from the City, he is received by the world. From the ends of the earth men come to meet the fugitive with bread — even if the fury of Semei, of Gerard of Angoulême, does not yet wholly cease to curse David. Will he, nill he — the sinner who sees and is angered — he is magnified in the sight of kings, bearing a crown of glory. Have not all the princes acknowledged that he is truly the elect of God? The kings of the Franks, of the English, of the Spains, and lastly of the Romans receive Innocent as pope, and recognize him as the singular bishop of their souls.

Only Achitophel still does not know that his counsel has already been laid bare and brought to nothing (II Reg. 17). In vain does the wretch labor to devise malice against the people of God, and to plot against the saints who hold most firmly to the holy one and scorn to bend the knee before Baal. By no fraud will he prevail to obtain for his parricide the kingdom over Israel and over the holy city, which is the Church of the living God, the pillar of faith and the ground of truth. A threefold cord is hard to break (Eccle. 4:12): **the election by the better men, the approval of the more, and — what is more effective than these — the testimony of his character, commend Innocent to all, and confirm him supreme pontiff.**

3. For this, Father, your own judgment too is awaited — like rain upon the fleece, though it come late. We do not blame a slowness that savors of gravity and wipes away the mark of levity. For Mary did not answer at once the angel who greeted her, but first considered what manner of greeting this might be (Luc. 1:29); and Timothy is commanded to impose hands hastily on no man (I Tim. 5:22). Yet I say — I who am known to the pontiff: Nothing in excess; I say as a familiar and a friend: Be not more wise than it behooveth to be wise (Rom. 12:3). It shames me, I confess, that the most ancient serpent, with new audacity, leaving aside silly women, has been seen to attempt even the strength of your breast, and has dared to shake so great a pillar of the Church. But we are confident that though he shake it, he shall not cast it down: for the friend of the Bridegroom stands, and rejoices at the voice of the Bridegroom (Joan. 3:29) — the voice of exultation and salvation, the voice of unity and peace.

Letter 125 — To Master Geoffrey of Loreto (PL 182, coll. 269–270)

He asks his help in upholding the pontificate of Innocent against the schism of Petrus Leonis.

1. In the flower we look for fragrance, in the fruit for savor. Drawn by the fragrance, dearest brother, of your name — oil poured out — we desire to know you also by the fruit of your work. For not we only, but God himself, who needs no one, has yet need at this hour of your work, if you do not hold back. It is glorious for you to be able to be God's co-worker; to be able and not to be, is ruinous. Moreover, you have favor with God and men; you have knowledge; you have the spirit of liberty; you have a word living and effectual, and seasoned with salt: with such powers you ought not to fail the bride of Christ in so great a crisis, since you are the friend of the Bridegroom. For a friend is proved in necessity. What then? Are you at rest for yourself, while your mother the Church is grievously troubled? Rest has had its seasons, and holy leisure has hitherto pursued its own occupations freely and gladly. Now it is time to act, for they have scattered the law. That beast of the Apocalypse, to whom is given a mouth speaking blasphemies and leave to make war upon the saints (Apoc. 13:5-7), occupies the chair of Peter, like a lion ready for the prey. And another beast hisses beside you, like a whelp lurking in hidden places. The one is the fiercer, the other the more cunning; and they have met together as one against the Lord and against his anointed. Let us make haste to burst their bonds asunder, and to cast their yoke from us.
2. We in our parts, together with other servants of God kindled with divine fire, have labored, God working with us, to gather the peoples into one, and the kings, to break up the conspiracy of the wicked and to destroy every height that exalts itself against the knowledge of God. Nor without fruit. The kings of Germany, of France, of

England, of Scotland, of the Spains, and of Jerusalem, with all the clergy and the peoples, favor and adhere to the lord Innocent, as sons to a father, as members to the head, careful to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. **And deservedly does the Church receive him, whose reputation is the brighter, and whose election is found the sounder — prevailing, namely, both in the number and in the merit of the electors.** But you, brother — why are you still remiss? How long shall your industry, ill-secure while the serpent is at the door, lie drowsing? We know indeed that you, a son of peace, can by no argument be induced to desert unity; but truly that is not enough, unless you also study to defend it, and to war down with all your strength those who trouble it. And do not fear the loss of your quiet: it will be repaid with no small increase of your glory, if that wild beast in your neighborhood, by your effort, be tamed or be silenced, and the piety of God snatch from the mouth of the Lion, by your hand, so great a prey of the Church — I mean the Count of Poitiers.

Letter 126 — To the bishops of Aquitaine, against Gerard of Angoulême (PL 182, coll. 270–281)

He defends excellently the cause of Innocent as legitimate pontiff against Gerard of Angoulême, who was playing the schismatic's part; he depicts his character and foils his subterfuges.

To the lords and honorable fathers, the holy bishops by the grace of God of Limoges, Poitiers, Périgueux, and Saintes: brother BERNARD, called abbot of Clairvaux — constancy in adversity.

1. Virtue is acquired in peace, tested in pressure, approved in victory. The time has come, reverend fathers, worthy of all regard, when yours — if you have any — can no longer be allowed to lie hidden or to slumber. For the enemy's sword, which now once more seems to threaten death to the whole body of Christ, hangs above your necks most of all, and rages against you the more fiercely for being close at hand: so that under its daily assaults you are compelled either to resist bravely or — which God forbid! — to yield basely. For that man who loves to hold the first place among you — Diotrophes — does not receive you; for he does not acknowledge him whom, together with you, the whole Church embraces as coming in the name of the Lord. Not this man, I say, but one who comes in his own name — him he receives. No wonder. He himself, tireless, pants after a great name, even at his age. Nor is it on false or uncertain report that I am led to tax the man with vanity of this kind: I judge him out of his own mouth. For in the familiar letters he lately wrote to the chancellor, does he not beg — the more unworthily, the more humbly — to be honored with the burden and the title of the legation? Would that he had obtained it! Ambition gratified would perhaps have done less harm than ambition thwarted. Then he would have hurt himself alone, or almost alone; now he rages against the world. Do you see what the love of glory does? A legation is a heavy pack, above all for aged shoulders — who does not know it? And yet to this most aged of men it seems a heavier penalty to live the little remnant of his days without that penalty.
2. But perhaps he will plead that he is being judged on suspicion, and will accuse us of rashness for censuring in his secret intentions what we have not proved. I confess, in this matter I am suspicious; and I do not know whether the simplest of men could judge otherwise, where the inference is so plain. To relate the simple course of events briefly: he writes first, or among the first, to Pope Innocent; he asks for the legation;

he does not obtain it. He takes offense, springs away from the one, crosses to the other, and boasts himself his legate. If he had either not asked it of the former beforehand, or not accepted it afterwards from the latter, one might have believed that in his defection he had some other motive in view, even if not an upright one; as it is, he has no excuse for his ambition. In fine, let him even now lay down the now-empty name of legate (for the function he has lost), and I for my part will rid myself of this suspicion, if I can; if I cannot, I shall suspect against my will, and blame my own intemperance. But it will be hard to persuade him — that I know. Naturally: a man long accounted great among his own blushes to appear less than himself. Here we recognize what Scripture speaks of: the shame that brings sin (Eccli. 4:25). And is it not a great sin and a very great offense — this proud bashfulness, by which earth and ashes is ashamed, I do not say to be subject, but not to lord it?

3. For this cause, then, the man has left that father of his, holy Innocent (for so he used to name him), and his mother, holy Church catholic; and he cleaves to his schism-leader, and the two are one in vanity. They have struck a covenant with each other, and devised malice against the people of God. Scale is joined to scale, and there is no vent between them (Job 41:7). The one writes the other up as pope; the other, in turn, writes him up as legate — that they may deceive each other into the same vanity. They console one another, protect one another, commend one another; yet each for himself, not for the other. Naturally: they are men who love themselves. With equal zeal indeed they have met together against the Lord and against his anointed; but their intentions by no means agree. Each seeks from the other the things that are his own — and that, which it is wicked even to dare, in the inheritance of Christ. What are they attempting before your eyes, if you suffer it, but to proscribe Christ? Already the legate coins new bishops among you for his pope, lest he be pope for himself alone. And not as successors to the dead, but as invaders upon the living he thrusts them in, propped by tyrannical power — having found his opportunity in the malice of princes who persecute the bishops of their own cities with unjust hatred. So he sits in ambush with the rich in secret places, to slay the innocent. Through such a gate he enters the sheepfold.
4. And does the legate transact such things for his pope for nothing? Behold — as he boasts — the other has added to his old legation the whole of France and Burgundy. He can add, if he likes, the Medes and the Persians and the middle borders of Decapolis. Why not the lands beyond the Sarmatians too, and in short whatever place his foot has trodden — let it be his, that he may glory at least in empty names! O man with no less want of shame than want of sense, mindful neither of the fear of God nor of his own honor! He thinks he is not seen, when he is the mockery and the derision of all who are round about him. And deservedly. For assuredly he uses the sanctuary as a market: and like a trader hunting his profits, sounding now this seller, now that, so as to buy in the end what he covets from the one who will let him have it cheapest — so this man, anxiously shopping here and there for ecclesiastical dignity, chose at last, at his own good pleasure, to have that man for pope who would consent to have him for legate. So then — unless you be legate, Rome cannot have a pope? Whence this privilege of yours in the Church of God? Who granted you this prerogative in the inheritance of Christ? Do you possess the sanctuary of God by inheritance? For as long as there was any hope of earning the lord Innocent's favor by your shameful and shameless petition, that holy man — you yourself writing it — was pope too. How then do you now denounce him as schismatic? Did his sanctity and his papacy vanish together with that vain hope of yours? Strange, that from the same fountain sweet and bitter could flow in so short a space! Yesterday catholic, holy, supreme pontiff; today worthless, schismatic, a disturber. Yesterday father Innocent; today Gregory, deacon of Sant'Angelo. And so from one mouth indeed, but assuredly from a double heart,

contraries have come forth. Deceitful lips have spoken with a heart and a heart. But a man whose heart-and-heart lashes his conscience, whose Yes-and-No forks his tongue — do you suppose there is fear of God in his mind, or shame on his brow? Ill does he provide, as the Apostle bids, things good in the sight of God and of men (II Cor. 8:21), who after the manner of that unjust judge neither fears God nor reverences man (Luc. 18:2).

5. And surely ambition, when it breaks out into shamelessness, loses its efficacy; when a base passion shows itself, its effect perishes. Ambition, the mother of hypocrisy, loves lurking-places and darkness; it cannot bear the light. Ambition, a filthy vice, lies at the bottom; yet it eyes every height, though it shrinks from being eyed itself. No wonder: it must needs miss what it desires unless it beware of witnesses. For the more glory is courted, the less it is caught, wherever the courting is caught out. What, in short, is so inglorious as to be caught coveting glory — above all among bishops? Even the simple Christian ought not to glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. The ambitious man will be illustrious so long as he moves in the night; so long as his traffic in base gain walks about in darkness, the hypocrite may seem just and holy — but only to the eye that sees the face. But when shamelessness or imprudence casts out of doors what lay hidden in the conscience, does not the intemperate appetite show itself readier for confusion than prompt for glory? Thus in very truth is proved what we read: Their glory is in their shame, who mind earthly things (Philipp. 3:19); and again: If I glorify myself, my glory is nothing (Joan. 8:54). And in the man who is of this kind is fulfilled what the holy Prophet imprecates — upon hypocrites, if I mistake not: Let them be, he says, as the grass upon the housetops, which withereth before it be plucked up (Psal. 128:5). Shame has not so far perished from mortals that naked and shameless ambition should be honored even by them — above all in an old man and a priest, whom this childish vanity disgraces the more, as greater gravity and greater holiness befit him: and though he be blessed to his face by the flatterer, behind his back he is derided by all. There is a certain sober and, so to speak, circumspect ambition, that at least works warily, if not chastely: if it can advance, it manages its business in secret; if not, it stays within itself and does not desert the shadow of shame. Such a man, even if he does not yet fear God unto salvation, still keeps a measure of decency out of inborn bashfulness, because he reveres men and blushes before the public.
6. But what is this headlong and brazen lust of ruling, that for the sake of a legation of scarcely a year (as is plain to all) it neither spares its own old age nor defers to its own priesthood; and then does not spare even the side of the Saviour — that side which, in water and blood, brought forth redemption for a people to be gathered into the unity of faith — so that whoever should attempt to divide those whom He gathered, and thence redeemed, would prove himself no Christian but Antichrist, guilty of the death and cross of Christ? O impatient, unbridled greed of base gain! O intemperate fever! O blind and shameful ambition! First — openly and brazenly, as I have said, and he himself, for shame! does not deny it — he tries the Catholic with a petition disgraceful enough; then, smarting at the rebuff, without hesitation he takes refuge with the schismatic; and having received from a sacrilegious hand the power he had wickedly coveted, he does not fear to pierce cruelly, a second time, the side of the Lord of glory. For he divides the Church, for which that side was divided on the cross — and he too, beyond doubt, shall look upon him whom he has pierced. Assuredly the Lord will be known executing judgments, who now, suffering wrong, is ignored. For when he shall begin to do judgment for all who suffer wrong, and to plead with equity for the meek of the earth — think you he will be able to turn his ear from his dearest bride, when she cries out, standing against those who have straitened her? No: he will by no means be able not to hear her lament: My friends and my

neighbors have drawn near and stood against me; and they that were near me stood afar off, and they that sought my soul used violence (Psal. 37:12-13). For how shall he fail to recognize bone of his bones and flesh of his flesh — nay rather, by now, in a manner, spirit of his spirit? As if she were not that beloved one whose beauty he desired, whose form he put on, to whom by marvelous condescension he bound himself in chaste and undivided embraces, so that they were two in one flesh — one day to be one in one spirit! For though he had known Christ according to the flesh, yet now he will know him so no longer: because the Christ the Lord is a spirit before her face; cleaving to him she will be one spirit, when — death swallowed up in victory — what is weak of the flesh shall have grown strong in the strength of the spirit; when the Bridegroom of glory shall present her to himself, his glorious dove, his perfect one, his fair one, having no spot of sin nor wrinkle of corruption, nor any such thing.

7. While I gladly linger over these things, I have almost forgotten my undertaking — so eager am I to redeem the time, for the days are evil. Devotion lifts me when I stray beyond bounds, but zeal calls me back; and where I am carried away, there too I am forced to fall back and mourn my grief. He dares — I say it even weeping — this enemy of the cross of Christ, to drive from their sees the saints who will not adore the beast which has opened its mouth in blasphemies, to blaspheme the name of God and his tabernacle (Apoc. 13:6). He attempts to set up altar against altar, and is not confounded to confound right and wrong. He strives to thrust abbots upon abbots, bishops upon bishops; to remove Catholics, to promote schismatics. Wretched and pitiable, those who consent to be promoted so — and by him! For he compasses sea and land to make one bishop; and when he has made him, he makes him twofold more a child of hell than himself. And what, think you, is the cause of so great a fury? None other, surely, than that the angelic apportionment displeases mortal men — glory to God, peace to men; and while they usurp the glory, they trouble the peace. He alone deserves glory, who alone does wonderful things; as the Apostle says: To God alone be honor and glory (I Tim. 1:17). For our race, it goes well with us if we are given to enjoy the peace of God, peace with God — and that by his happy mercy. How then shall the peace of men stand before God, or with God, if God's own glory cannot be safe with men? O foolish sons of Adam, who, despising peace and coveting glory, lose both peace and glory! For this cause, in fine, the God of vengeance has now shaken the earth and troubled it; he has shown his people hard things; he has made us drink the wine of compunction.
8. Will we, nill we, the truth of the Holy Spirit must at some time be fulfilled, and that falling-away must come to pass which we read foretold in the Scriptures by the prophetic spirit (II Thess. 2:3): but woe to the man through whom it comes! Better were it for him if that man had not been born. And who is he, but the man of sin, who upon the catholic — elected by catholics, and canonically — invaded the holy place: a place he coveted, however, not because it is holy, but because it is highest? He invaded it, I say — invaded it with arms, with fire, with money, not by merit of life or of virtues; he arrived by the path on which he stands, and stands on the path by which he arrived. For that thing which he vaunts — not an election but a faction of his sworn partisans — was a mere shadow, a pretext, a veil of malice. It can be called an election — but shamelessly, but lyingly. **For the ecclesiastical and authentic rule stands: after a first election, there is not a second. When a first has been celebrated, that which is presumed second is not second, but null.** For even if something proceeded less solemnly, or less in order, in the one that preceded — as the enemies of unity contend — ought a second nevertheless to have been presumed, before the earlier had first been examined by reason and quashed by judgment? Therefore those who hasten to thrust themselves on top, and who made speed no less

rashly to impose hands upon a rash man, though the Apostle forbids — Impose hands hastily upon no man (I Tim. 5:22) — these beyond doubt have the greater sin; these stand forth the authors of the schism, these the princes of this great warfare.

9. And now, forsooth, they demand a judgment — which they ought to have awaited before; and the justice which, when offered in its proper place, they had withheld, they now at last offer: namely, so that if it be refused, they may seem the just ones; and if it be accepted, then, while the parties litigate between themselves, delay may buy time — and meanwhile something may turn up. Or do you despair of your own justice, and no longer fear the damage growing, whatever issue the cause may take? “Whatever has been done hitherto,” they say, “we now ask only a hearing: we are ready to undergo judgment.” It is evasion. In all your impious enterprise, what else is left to you that you could bring forward, to seduce the simple, to arm the malevolent, to cloak your own malice? If you did not say this, what would you say? **But God has already judged what man belatedly reopens: and he has judged by the evidence of the deed, not by the sentence of a decree.** Shall human rashness dare to retract the judgment of God? What if God himself pleads and cries by the prophet: Men have taken judgment away from me? There is no counsel against the counsel of the Lord: his word runs swiftly, gathering into one the peoples and the kings, that they may serve and obey the lord Pope Innocent. Who shall recall it? That the judgment is God’s, the archbishops Walter of Ravenna, Hildegard of Tarragona, Norbert of Magdeburg, Conrad of Salzburg have perceived, and consented. That the judgment is God’s, the bishops have recognized, and acquiesced: Egbert of Münster, Hildebrand of Pistoia, Bernard of Pavia, Landulf of Asti, Hugh of Grenoble, Bernard of Parma. The singular glory and eminent holiness of these men, and an authority to be revered even by enemies, have easily persuaded us, who hold a lesser place both of merit and of office, either to err with them or to be wise with them. I say nothing of the multitude of the rest — of Tuscany, Campania, Lombardy, Germany, and Aquitaine, in fine of all the Gauls and the Spains, and of the whole Eastern Church besides — archbishops and bishops alike, whose names are in the book of life, though the brevity of a letter does not admit them.
10. **All these, unanimous** — not hired with money, not seduced by fraud, not enticed by private love of flesh or kinship, not driven by fear of secular power, but beyond doubt neither ignorant of the will of God nor dissembling it — **frankly refused Petrus Leonis, and with assurance received Gregory as Pope Innocent.** Of our own countrymen, none indeed is named in this letter: for a summary does not bear naming all, and an invidious singling-out of some would not escape the mark of flattery. But I must not pass over the holy ones who, dead to the world, live the better to God, whose life is hidden with Christ in glory — where surely they diligently seek, and undoubtedly find, the good pleasure of God, being solicitous how they may please him. And so the Camaldolese, the Vallombrosans, the Carthusians, the Cluniacs, and those of Marmoutier; my own Cistercians too, the monks of Caen, of Tiron, and of Savigny — **in fine, the university and unanimity of the brethren, clerics and monks alike, of regular life and proven conversation, following their bishops as flocks their shepherds, adhere firmly to Innocent, favor him sincerely, obey him humbly, and faithfully recognize him as the true successor of the apostles.**
11. What of the kings and princes of the earth? Do they not, in the same spirit, together with the peoples subject to them, likewise embrace Innocent, they too confessing him pope and bishop of their souls? Who, in short, in any station of life, being a man of distinction and good name, does not judge the same? And yet these men still cry out against it, with I know not what contentious importunity and importunate contention.

They summon the world to court, and with their handful demand that the universality be judged; and they who pre-judged in the election contend to re-judge the confirmation — then acting over-hastily, now retracting preposterously. Who, I ask, could gather into one place such armies of princes of both orders — to say nothing of the peoples — and bring them in for examination? Who could suffice to persuade so many thousands of holy men to destroy again what they had built, and to lead themselves away into prevarication? What place, moreover, would be large enough for all, safe for all? **For it is the business of the universal Church, not the cause of a single person.** You see that the calumny you frame against your mother is built on an impossibility: nay, you dig a pit for yourselves into which you may fall headlong, and knot a snare in which you may be held, so as never to return to the bosom of your mother. A pretext will never be wanting to him who wishes to withdraw from a friend.

12. But be it so. Let God change his counsel (I speak after the manner of men); let him revoke his sentence, and summon a council from the ends of the earth; let him suffer the same cause to be judged twice — a thing he himself does not do: whom, pray, will they grant as judges over themselves? For all men are on one side or the other, and the parties will not easily agree upon a court: and so that great assembly will be worn out for strife rather than for peace. Next, I should like to know to whom he, meanwhile, would be willing to entrust Rome — Rome, which he has coveted with such love for so long a time, acquired with such labor and expense, possesses with such pomp, and fears with such shame to lose; lest the whole world be seen to have assembled in vain if, when he falls from his cause, he yet does not fall from Rome. Otherwise, who enters a suit already stripped of the thing in dispute? Certainly neither the laws compel it, nor the canons. And we say these things, not as distrusting our own justice, but as being on guard against your cunning. For God has already brought forth his justice as the light, and his judgment as the noonday — even if to a blind man neither the light appears nor the noonday shines: for as his darkness is, so also is his light.
13. Two things, then, are in contention: which of the two may more rightly be seen to be Pope. On the first point — if you compare the persons — that I may seem neither to disparage nor to flatter either, I will say what you will find said everywhere, and what I think no one denies: namely, that the life and reputation of our Innocent fears no rival, while the other's is not safe even from a friend. Next, if you examine the elections, ours again at once presents itself as **purser in its promotion, more probable in its reason, and prior in time.** Of the time there is no dispute; the other two points are proved by the merits — and by the dignity — of the electors. For here, unless I am deceived, you will find the **sounder part:** bishops, and cardinal deacons and priests alike — the very men whose concern the election of the supreme pontiff chiefly is, and as many as suffice for a valid election according to the decrees of the fathers. And what of the consecration? Have we not the bishop of Ostia, to whom it especially belongs? **Since, then, the elect is held the worthier, the election the sounder, and the proceeding the more orderly — by what reason, nay by what obstinacy, do these men, against right and law and the vows of all good men, attempt to set another over the unwilling and resisting Church of God, and to depose him?**
14. Against an attempt so malignant, so unworthy, so rash, you see, most reverend and illustrious Fathers, that resistance must be made with all your strength — a duty that belongs to the whole family of God, but to you and yours above all, if indeed the zeal of God's house has eaten your souls. You, I say, and yours must above all watch and pray, that you enter not into temptation. On that side assuredly there is need of

greater fortitude and caution, where the adversary presses more sharply and the greater force of the war bears down. How savage and how cunning an enemy has risen against you, you know by your own experience. Alas! how far his malice has already advanced in those parts, on the strength of the power he has received, raging with both kinds of malignity — force and fraud! But shall malice in the end conquer wisdom? Yet this is its hour, and the power of darkness. But it is the last hour, and the power passes quickly. Be not terrified; be not seduced. Christ, the power of God and the wisdom of God, is with you — and it is his cause. Take courage: he has overcome the world; he is faithful, and will not suffer you to be tempted above that which you are able. Do you see the fool with firm root? Doubt not, his comeliness shall be cursed at once. For the Lord will not leave the rod of sinners long upon the lot of the just. Meanwhile it is for your vigilance, according to your office, to provide carefully for your own — as indeed you do — that the just stretch not forth their hands to iniquity. A prayer for the Catholics: Do good, O Lord, to those that are good and upright of heart (Psal. 124:4). For the schismatics: Fill their faces with shame, O Lord, that they may seek thy name (Psal. 82:17).

Letter 127 — To William, Count of Poitiers and Duke of Aquitaine, in the person of Hugh, Duke of Burgundy (PL 182, coll. 281–282)

He exhorts William, who favored the antipope Anacletus, to receive Innocent, the true pontiff.

To WILLIAM, by the grace of God illustrious Count of Poitiers and Duke of the Aquitanians: HUGH, by the same grace Duke of Burgundy — that he may fear the Terrible One, even him who takes away the spirit of princes.

1. I can no longer bear to dissemble your error — I who am near to you in blood and a friend at heart. If one of the people goes astray, he perishes alone; but the error of a prince entangles many, and harms as many as he rules. He through whom kings reign has set us over his peoples to protect them, not to subvert them — as ministers, plainly, of his holy Church, not as lords. And since you are known to have served that ministry at other times worthily, according to the greatness of your power, and laudably, I marvel by what cunning that prudence of yours has now been circumvented into deserting that same mother and mistress of yours in the evil day — unless perhaps those counsellors of yours are trying to persuade you of this too: that the universal Church has been reduced to the single house of Petrus Leonis. Lying men! — whom Truth, as also their head Antichrist, destroys with the breath of his mouth, affirming through the mouth of David that she is spread abroad to all the ends of the earth and to all the families of the nations (Psal. 21:28).
2. They have, it is true, the duke of Apulia — but him alone among the princes, and him bought with the laughable price of a usurped crown. In fine, what good, what virtue, what honor do they allege of their supreme pontiff, to draw us too to his favor? If the things that report divulges everywhere are true, he is not worthy of power over a single hamlet; if they are not true, still it befits the head of the Church to have not only soundness of life but fairness of fame. **It is safer, therefore, for you, my dearest kinsman, in the reception of the universal pope, not to depart from the consensus and counsel of the universality: him whom all the religious orders, whom the universality of kings have received, it is for you also honorable and salutary to receive.** Of the lord Pope Innocent both the innocent life and the

unblemished fame and the canonical election are proclaimed. The first two not even his enemies deny; the third suffered calumny — but through the most Christian Lothair the false calumniators were lately caught in their own lie.